SpeechGeek



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As 2013 marches boldly and coldly toward its final days, the online monolith that is Amazon is experimenting with its drone delivery service. Though (at the time of this publication) customers won't anticipate their bulk orders of lip balm to be delivered by autonomous robots until at least 2015, folks are increasingly curious about the most efficient way to obtain their purchases. While we certainly respect the innovation and sheer "woah"-ness of the delivery drones, your friendly neighborhood **SpeechGeek** plans to stick with our current strategy of providing prompt digital downloads for online purchases. As recognized digital publishers by the National Forensic League, your electronic copy of **SpeechGeek** scripts is all you need to get competing. Don't forget your suit, though. That's pretty important, too.

If you're in need of printed scripts, stopwatches, or buttons – we still have you covered! While we can't promise delivery via an automated drone just yet (maybe by the time we're publishing Season Thirty), we do promise to package and ship your items at quickly as our human hands can do it. Welcome to a new year and five new interp scripts!

Corey Alderdice
Publisher

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Pigskin

by Richard Shelton

SCENE ONE

MARK. Every family has rituals. Some involve particular foods, places, or behaviors. Our ritual centers on the pigskin.

DAD. Get 'yer jersey on, son. The game is about to begin.

MARK. My earliest memories practically have buffalo sauce stains. My father and I would sit next to each other on the couch, surrounded by the weekly smorgasbord of junky food my otherwise healthy mother would lovingly prepare.

DAD. (*shouting at television*) Come on, Murphries, you better deliver a victory this time.

MARK. Outside of football, my dad and I couldn't be more different. I guess you could say I was a bit softer than my dad. I preferred to read and listen to music while he…

DAD. (*screaming*) Murphries? What? Was there a bone in the Gatorade? BECAUSE YOU'RE CHOKING!

MARK. …was tougher than me. Very tough.

DAD. You've gotta be kidding me! Can't you take a hit?

MARK. As I got older, high school football seemed like the obvious path way to a little bit of father-son bonding. Unfortunately, the only one I ended up bonding with was J.T.

J.T. (*taunting MARK)* Come on, Mark. You'd better deliver a victory this time.

MARK. I don't know what made him tic.

J.T. What? Was there a bone in your Gatorade? Because you're choking.

MARK. But I knew one thing.

J.T. (*shoves)* Can't you take a hit?

MARK. He wouldn't be content until I was sacked.

SCENE TWO

(*MARK and J.T. are in uniform during a practice. The scene freezes when MARK addresses the audience.*)

J.T. (*grunts and stretches*) Hunh! Ungh! Ahhh… I tell you something, nothing gets me going like crushing bodies on a Saturday morning, eh?

MARK. (*to himself, rolling his eyes and adjusting his mouth guard)* Yeah, right.

J.T. What?

MARK. Huh?

J.T. What did you say?

MARK. Oh, nothing.

J.T. (*moves a bit closer to him*) So, you're telling me you didn't just mumble something under your breath?

MARK. I mean, I did. But I…

J.T. But you what? You think I'm an idiot?

MARK. That's not what I said.

J.T. Then what did you say?

MARK. (*uncomfortable*) Yeah, right.

J.T. What's that supposed to mean?

MARK. Nothing. It means nothing.

J.T. (*laughs)* Oh, it means something. It means one of two things: (*nearing him, looming over in an intimidating fashion)* one, you're scared of getting hurt; or two, you're scared because you actually like a bunch of guys piling up on top of you. (*staring him down)* So, which is? How *scared* are you?

(*A whistle blows and MARK and J.T. get into their positions before MARK has an opportunity to respond.)*

MARK. (*in position, addressing the audience)* Football quickly became a metaphor for my life. (*In slow motion, they begin to move as if in the middle of a play.)* Moments of quiet punctuated by crashing violence. There is a tiny thing – maybe it's a ball, success, or acceptance, and it is being savagely chased and fiercely protected by all these guys. We're all after the same thing, but we're all in each other's way. You want to win? It's them or us. No matter how much we try to protect ourselves, no matter how thick the helmets or how much padding we wear, underneath it all we are still soft. (*J.T. collides into MARK and gives an extra shove during the last line.)* We are still capable of getting hurt. (*MARK stumbles over having had the wind knocked out of him. He is now back in the present scene with J.T.*)

J.T. (*smug)* Oops.

MARK. Dude.

J.T. What?

MARK. Why did you do that?

J.T. Do what? My job?

MARK. You know what I'm talking about.

J.T. Look, if you're going to cry every time you get hurt, then maybe you should play on another team. (*narrowing his eyes)* You want to "play for the other team?"

MARK. Cut it out.

J.T. No, no. C'mon Mark. (*starts poking and prodding him)* Wouldn't you rather join the cheerleaders? Clap your hands? Shake your little pom poms?

MARK. I'm tired of putting up with your crap, okay? Just back off, J.T.

J.T. (*slams up against him and remains smiling before growling out a threat)* Let's make one thing clear. If you ever, and I mean **ever,** talk like that to me again, I'll break your spine in three places and make it look like an accident. I'll sack you so hard you'll be sent back three grades because your brain will be turned into Jell-O. (*leans in*

closer) I can make your life in this school a living nightmare. So watch what you say. (*MARK doesn't respond.*) You got it? (*MARK nods.*)

SCENE THREE

(*MARK addresses the audience.*)

MARK. It went on like this for weeks. If it wasn't on the field, it was in the locker room. If he wasn't crashing his big, lumbering body into mine, he was antagonizing and threatening me. I was exhausted, mentally and physically. I'd finally had enough. (*enters an office)* Coach?

COACH. Hey, Mark, how's it going?

MARK. Hey, coach. I was wondering if I could talk to you for a minute.

COACH. Sure thing, man. What's going on?

MARK. It's J.T., sir.

COACH. (*nods knowingly*) Yeah, J.T. is a force of nature, all right.

MARK. Maybe. It's a bit more complicated than that.

COACH. Really?

MARK. (*uncomfortable*) He takes things too far, sir, on and off the field.

COACH. How so?

MARK. I dunno, coach. During and in between plays, he goes out of his way to shove and kick me. Plus, he's said some really messed up things to me in the locker room, and...

COACH. (*cutting him off)* So he plays too rough and makes bad jokes, is that it?

MARK. No, it's more than that, Coach.

COACH. Look, Mark, I'm going to stop you right there. I get it. J.T. is a little rough around the edges and can rub people the wrong way. But you've got to remember that this isn't the chess team or the math club—this is football. The guys around here are expected to be tough, aggressive even. Sometimes that spills over into real life a bit more than we'd like, but it's an important lesson on growing a thicker skin. I like you, Mark, but this is typical locker room behav ior. I need you to toughen up. Just ignore J.T. and get on with your practice. Things will get better in the long run.

SCENE FOUR

(*MARK is depressed and defeated after his meeting with COACH.)*

MARK. (*addressing audience)* "It'll get better?" Really? Is that the best Coach could come up with? I'm just supposed to let it roll off my back? I'm just supposed to keep getting humiliated and teased and knocked down and (*J.T. enters from behind and slams into MARK.)*

J.T. NARC!

MARK. What?!

J.T. (*physically intimidates MARK during the confrontation)* You NARC'd

on me to Coach!

MARK. You're acting crazy, man.

J.T. Don't lie to me! He pulled me in my office and told me to "shut up and cut it out" because he was hearing complaints from other players.

MARK. How do you know it was me?

J.T. It's so obvious. You're the only one around here who can't man up and take it. Any time I say or do anything you start getting all defensive and weepy like some little two-year-old. Why are you even on the football team?

MARK. (*anger begins to boil)* Back off, J.T.

J.T. What'sa matter? Am I too close to you?

MARK. I said… back… off.

J.T. I thought you liked being close to guys.

MARK. Back. OFF! (*shoves J.T.)*

J.T. Do you have a death wish?!

MARK. (*snaps)* YES. I WISH YOU WERE DEAD.

J.T. (*stares, stunned*) What?

MARK. Every night I said I wish you were dead. Every night when I come home from practice, I do my homework, eat my dinner, then I lie in bed and pray that something horrible happens to you. I pray for a car accident, or that you fall down the stairs, or that you choke, or have a heart attack, or that you just burst into flames. Every night I wish something horrible would happen to you so that for once, I can walk into school and not feel sick to my stomach about when I have to be around you. I'd finally be able to sleep, to think clearly, to not feel like I'm living my entire life dreading the moment I have to see your big, dumb, ugly, mean face. And every day when I come to practice and I see you here, I get disappointed that you're still walking around this planet. (*J.T. is silent.)* Great. Awesome. Well, whenever you're ready, just go ahead and crush my ribs or crack my skull or do whatever it is you plan on doing to me because I'm done. Do you hear me? DONE. I'm done with you. I'm done with this team. I'm done with everything.

J.T. (*quietly, but sternly, as if he could break into a violent outburst or tears*) You're not the only one.

MARK. That you pick on? There's a shock.

J.T. That's told me they wished I were dead.

MARK. So?

J.T. I hear it all the time, at home at least.

MARK. (*uncomfortable)* Uh… I'm sorry.

J.T. No, you're not. You meant it. They mean it. I know what people say about me, about my anger.

MARK. If this is some warped play for sympathy, it's not going to work. You've TORTURED me. Just because you have issues doesn't make it fair to take them out on me.

J.T. (*lashing back)* Tell me about fair, Mark. I'd love to hear about the fair world you live in. Tell me about this "fair" world where screwing up doesn't mean you get hit upside the head, this fair world where you don't have to make your own meals and eat alone every night, this fair world where you don't walk around so angry at everything that you just want to make everything explode so you can be at peace for five minutes.

MARK. Look man, I get it.

J.T. YOU DON'T. You're in the AP courses. You make good grades. You've got college and internships and a life set up for you. I've got NOTHING to look forward to after this. And you take it for granted, like you need to be good at football on top of all the other great things going on in your life. You've got it so good and you don't even know it.

MARK. J.T…

J.T. Forget it. (*exits)*

MARK. (*to audience)* They tell you that you have to have a thick skin to play this game. Man up, they say, let go of fear, channel your inner champion, and all of that other motivational machismo. They forget to tell you when to take off the helmet and pads, when you get to go back to being this lumbering vulnerable mass of flesh. And you just don't know what to do with yourself. Maybe that's the real goal of the game: not to pass a ball over a goal line but for guys to keep smashing into each other until we forget how easily we can make the other one bend and snap.